

# WWI BOMBERS AND GROUND ATTACK AIRCRAFT

WHILE WWI GENERALS welcomed the chance to launch air raids behind enemy lines, the effectiveness of tactical bombing was limited by the small bomb payload that bombers could carry and by their vulnerability to enemy fighters, which forced them to stick to inaccurate night raids for much of the war. Still, by 1918, tactical bombers such as the Breguet 14B2 and Airco D.H.4 were making a significant impact. While the British chiefly used fighters to attack enemy ground forces during land battles, the Germans used dedicated ground-attack aircraft, such as the Halberstadt and the all-metal Junkers J 4, able to take considerable punishment as its crew flew low over the trenches. Some very large, multiengined aircraft were developed for strategic bombing. The biggest were the Zeppelin R-planes, which supported Gothas in the bombing campaign against England.

## RUSSIAN GIANT

*Sikorsky's Il'ya Muromets was the world's first four-engined bomber. During WWI, over 75 Il'ya Muromets were deployed in a special squadron on the Eastern Front for bombing and reconnaissance missions from 1915 onward.*



## A.E.G. G.IV

Over 540 of the G series of excellent twin-engined medium bombers were built by Allgemeine Elektricitäts Gesellschaft from 1915. The most numerous (around 400) was the G.IV, which entered service in late 1916 as a short-range tactical bomber but was later relegated to photo-reconnaissance duties.



**ENGINE** 2 x 260hp Mercedes D.IVa 6-cylinder inline

**WINGSPAN** 60ft 5in (18.4m) **LENGTH** 31ft 10in (9.7m)

**TOP SPEED** 103mph (165kph) **CREW** 3

**ARMAMENT** 2 x machine guns; 882lb (400kg) bombload

## Airco D.H.4

Designed in 1916 as a high-speed day bomber, the D.H.4 was first used as a bomber over the Western Front in March 1917. It was also used for reconnaissance, antisubmarine patrols, and even as a night fighter.

**ENGINE** 375hp Rolls-Royce Eagle VII water-cooled V-12

**WINGSPAN** 42ft 4in (12.9m) **LENGTH** 30ft 8in (9.4m)

**TOP SPEED** 143mph (230kph) **CREW** 2

**ARMAMENT** 4 x machine guns; 460lb (209kg) bombload



## Breguet 14B2

On November 21, 1916, Louis Breguet personally flew the Breguet 14 prototype, and by 1926, over 8,000 had been built. As well as the bomber, reconnaissance and training versions were also produced. The type had a long postwar career with many foreign air forces.



**ENGINE** 300hp Renault 12 Fox V-12

**WINGSPAN** 47ft 2in (14.4m) **LENGTH** 29ft 1in (8.9m)

**TOP SPEED** 110mph (177kph) **CREW** 2

**ARMAMENT** 3 x machine guns; 661lb (300kg) bombload

## Caproni Ca 42 (Ca 4)

Together with Sikorsky, Caproni pioneered the construction of giant aircraft. The three-engined Ca 30 appeared in 1913, and the series developed throughout WWI, with most variants employing the single pusher and double tractor engine layout.



**ENGINE** 3 x 270hp Isotta-Fraschini water-cooled V-6

**WINGSPAN** 98ft 1in (29.9m) **LENGTH** 43ft (13.1m)

**TOP SPEED** 78mph (126kph) **CREW** 4

**ARMAMENT** 4 x machine guns; 3,197lb (1,450kg) bombload

## Gotha G.V

If to the British public every airship was a Zeppelin, then every German bomber was a Gotha. The G.IV first undertook daylight raids over southern England in May 1917, operating with virtual impunity at 15,000ft (4,575m). The improved G.V entered service in September and continued night raids to May 1918. Although a typical bombload was only six 110lb (50kg) bombs, the Gothas dropped nearly 187,435lb (85,000kg) of bombs on Britain for the loss of 24 aircraft.



**ENGINE** 2 x 260hp Mercedes D.IVa 6-cylinder inline

**WINGSPAN** 77ft 9in (23.7m) **LENGTH** 40ft (12.2m)

**TOP SPEED** 87mph (140kph) **CREW** 3

**ARMAMENT** 2 x machine guns; 1,102lb (500kg) bombload